

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Call it Operation Brass Attacks. On paper, the army, the navy and the air force are committed to 'joint-manship' or training to fight future wars together. In the sandstone corridors of the South Block these days, however, they are embroiled in an internecine conflict over how many more generals, air marshals and admirals they must have.

The 11-lakh strong army, which has over 35,000 officers and plans to add 95 more Major Generals and Lieutenant Generals, has opposed a proportionate increase in the number of air marshals and admirals in the air force and the navy. The first salvo was fired by the outgoing army chief General J.J. Singh in a strongly-worded letter to Defence Minister A.K. Antony last month, in which he opposed the proposed surge in the number of senior posts in the navy and IAF, saying this should only be commensurate with their roles and responsibilities. The army chief's letter prompted a strong rebuttal from the navy and IAF chiefs. In the midst of this bedlam, the implementation of a report by former defence secretary Ajai Vikram Singh, which recommended a proportionate increase in senior ranks for the three services, has stopped dead in its tracks.

The report, presented in 2004, actually aimed at giving the army a younger age profile. Phase I of the report recommended that officers would become captains after two years of service instead of four, majors in six years instead of 10 and Lt Colonels in 13 years instead of 19. It would mean that the army would have 36-year-old colonels (instead of 41-year-olds) and 44 year-old brigadiers (instead of 50-year-olds). To avoid creating an imbalance, these recommendations were applied to the two other services as well and implemented in late 2004. Phase II of the report, which proposed adding ranks for colonels and above, was de-

BATTLE OF THE BRASS

A nasty fight breaks out among the forces for senior positions

layed by a few years. An admiral recounts how the army had quietly pushed for the implementation of the second phase of the report, to swell the ranks of its existing 68 Lt Generals and 216 Major Generals, without telling IAF or the navy. The two services had to fight with the government to avail a similar increase in senior ranks. Yet the larger point being missed in the fracas is that the report was not to be implemented selectively but as a series of complementary steps designed to make the armed forces an attractive career option.

"The recommendations were meant to only gradually increase the number of senior officers in the armed forces and not become a one-time in-



ARMY CHIEF:
General J.J. Singh



IAF CHIEF: Air Chief
Marshal F.H. Major

WHY THEY'RE MIFFED

ARMY DOESN'T WANT IAF AND NAVY TO GET MORE SENIOR POSTS



ARMY PRESENT STRENGTH

NO. OF OFFICERS: 35,377

PROPOSED INCREASE 20 Lt Generals,
75 Major Generals



IAF PRESENT STRENGTH

NO. OF OFFICERS: 7,336

PROPOSED INCREASE 7 Air Marshals
31 Air Vice-Marshals